south of the Narmada, so that the war in the North was of no great concern to those in the South, who had their own loyalties. Yet it was the scattered Sunni Muslim community in India that had the strongest sense of shared identity, and in the wake of 1857 their religious leaders now began to ask themselves the same question that Shah Waliullah's son Shah Abdul Aziz had asked himself half a century earlier: how could Islam defend itself against the steady advance of British and Christian imperialism?

Two very different responses emerged, both claiming to be the authentic voice of Sunni tradition. The traditionalists argued for a return to pure Islam, 'Arabisation' and separatism. They found their first champions in Maulvi Nazeer Husain of Delhi and Siddiq Hasan Khan of Bhopal, founders of the Ahl-i-Hadith 'the Way of the Traditions (of the Prophet)' movement, which was Wahhabi in all but name. But these Ahl-i-Hadiths soon found themselves outflanked by a much more focused group of separatists led by Rashid Ahmad Gangohi and Muhammad Qasim Nanautwi, two former students of the Madrassa-i-Rahimiya. In the great uprising of 1857 they and a number of students and teachers from the Madrassa-i-Rahimiya had refused to ally themselves with Emperor Bahadur Shah in Delhi and had briefly set up their own Muslim theocracy outside Delhi at the village of Thana Bhawan. They had soon been broken up, with a number of survivors fleeing to Arabia. However, Rashid Ahmad Gangohi and Muhammad Qasim Nanautwi had stayed on in hiding – to emerge nine years later to co-found a little 'Arab' madrassa in the village of Deoband, in what is now Uttar Pradesh.[14]

With its uncompromising, separatist interpretation of Islam, the Deobandi creed ought to have withered on the vine. But a significant proportion of India's Muslims, finding themselves increasingly isolated and denied opportunities for advancement, rallied to its clear-cut laying down of the